

THE SLOW ATLAS



Thailand

Road Trip Atlas

Legendary routes, slowly travelled.

ROUTES • ITINERARIES • FOOD • PHRASES • PLANNING PAGES

A SLOW ATLAS GUIDE • VOLUME I

How to use this atlas



This is a road-tripper's companion to Thailand — written for travellers who would rather wind through mountain villages and roadside noodle stalls than rush between airports. Inside you'll find the country's most rewarding self-drive routes, a full day-by-day for the legendary Mae Hong Son Loop, and everything practical you need to do it well.

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ORIENTATION

Thailand at a glance

OI

THE ESSENTIALS

Capital

Bangkok (Krung Thep)

Language

Thai · English widely used in tourism

Currency

Thai baht (THB)

Drives on

The LEFT

Best months

November – February (cool & dry)

Avoid

March – April (haze in the north)

Plug

Type A / B / C · 230V

Time

GMT +7



Before you go

Thailand has three broad seasons, and choosing the right window matters more here than almost anywhere. Get it right and you'll have warm days and clear mountain views; get it wrong and you'll meet either monsoon downpours or a smoky northern sky.

Cool & dry

NOV – FEB

The sweet spot. Comfortable days, cool evenings in the hills, clear skies. Peak season — book ahead.

Hot

MAR – MAY

Very hot, and Mar–Apr brings agricultural haze across the north (Chiang Mai, Pai). Songkran (Thai New Year) mid-April is a joyous water festival.

Green & wet

JUN – OCT

Warm monsoon rains — usually short, heavy afternoon bursts. Lush, quiet and cheap. Some mountain roads get slippery; ride with care.

SLOW ATLAS TIP

For the Mae Hong Son Loop specifically, aim for late November to February. You'll get the famous sea of mist over the valleys at dawn and dry, grippy roads for those 1,864 curves.

Driving in Thailand

THE NON-NEGOTIABLES

- Carry an International Driving Permit (IDP) plus your home licence — police checks are common and your insurance depends on it.
- Drive on the LEFT. Give way to anything bigger; the road hierarchy is by size.
- Helmets are mandatory on scooters — and genuinely life-saving. Wear closed shoes.
- Avoid driving at night: unlit vehicles, animals, and the odd pothole.

SCOOTER VS. CAR

Scooter / motorbike

The classic way to ride the northern loops — freeing and cheap (around THB 200–300/day). Only if you're confident; mountain bends are unforgiving. Rent 125–150cc+ for the hills.

Car

Safer for families and the rainy season; air-con is a blessing in the heat. From around THB 900–1,400/day. International rental desks are at every major airport.

GOOD TO KNOW

- Fuel is cheap and stations (PTT, Bangchak) are frequent — but fill up before remote stretches like Mae Sariang to Mae Chaem.
- Download offline maps (Maps.me or Google offline) — signal drops in the mountains.
- Petrol stations often have clean toilets, good coffee (Café Amazon) and 7-Eleven snacks.
- An app like Grab is handy in cities when you'd rather not drive.

Money, SIM & health

MONEY

- The baht is cash-first once you leave the cities — carry small notes for stalls and tolls.
- ATMs are everywhere but charge around THB 220 per foreign withdrawal; take out larger amounts less often.
- Tipping isn't expected, but rounding up or leaving THB 20–50 is kind.

CONNECTIVITY

- Buy a tourist SIM (AIS, TrueMove, dtac) at the airport, or an eSIM before you fly. Data is fast and cheap.
- Coverage is excellent except deep in the mountains — hence offline maps.

HEALTH & SAFETY

- Tap water isn't drinkable — buy big bottles or use a filter. Ice in cafés is generally fine.
- Travel insurance that covers motorbike riding is essential (many policies exclude it).
- Carry a small kit: rehydration salts, plasters, antiseptic, and any meds you need.
- Emergency: dial 191 (police) or 1669 (ambulance). Tourist Police: 1155.

Culture & useful Thai

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ETIQUETTE THAT EARNS SMILES

- Return a 'wai' (palms together) with a smile — but you needn't initiate with staff.
- Never touch someone's head, and don't point your feet at people or Buddha images.
- Cover shoulders and knees at temples; remove shoes before entering.
- Keep your cool — visible anger makes you 'lose face' and rarely helps.
- Treat images of the King and monarchy with great respect (it's the law).

A LITTLE THAI GOES A LONG WAY

Hello	<i>Sawatdee (khrap/kha)</i>
Thank you	<i>Khop khun (khrap/kha)</i>
Yes / No	<i>Chai / Mai chai</i>
How much?	<i>Tao rai?</i>
Delicious	<i>Aroi!</i>
Not spicy, please	<i>Mai phet</i>
Where is...?	<i>...yu thi nai?</i>
Excuse me / sorry	<i>Khor thot</i>
Cheers!	<i>Chon kaew!</i>

Men end politely with 'khrap', women with 'kha'.

The four great routes

1 • Mae Hong Son Loop

▣ 600 KM • 5-7 DAYS

North. The crown jewel: 1,864 curves through misty mountains, hot springs, hill-tribe villages and the bohemian town of Pai. The heart of this atlas.

2 • The Andaman Coast

▣ 400 KM • 5-8 DAYS

South-west. Bangkok down to limestone-studded Krabi and Phuket — beaches, sea kayaking, and long-tail boats. Best Nov-Apr.

3 • Isaan & the North-East

▣ 700 KM • 6-9 DAYS

The Thailand few visitors see: Khmer temples, silk villages, sticky-rice country and the Mekong. Authentic, warm and wonderfully cheap.

4 • Bangkok – Kanchanaburi

▣ 250 KM • 3-4 DAYS

West. Waterfalls, the River Kwai, floating markets and Erawan's emerald pools — an easy first road trip from the capital.

The Mae Hong Son Loop

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Thailand's most loved drive traces a great circle through the north-western mountains from Chiang Mai. It is famous for its 1,864 marked curves — there's even a sticker to prove you survived them.

But the joy is in going slowly: dawn mist pooling in the valleys, roadside coffee, waterfalls, hot springs, and Shan-culture towns that feel a world away from Bangkok.

AT A GLANCE

Distance	≈600 km	Mae Hong Son
Duration	5–7 days (we suggest 7)	
Start / end	Chiang Mai	
Direction	Anti-clockwise (via Pai first)	
Vehicle	Scooter 150cc+ or a small car	
Best season	Nov – Feb	



The Mae Hong Son Loop

07

DAY 1

Chiang Mai – Pai

📏 135 km · 3–4 h

Ease in with the famous climb to Pai — 762 curves of forest and viewpoints. Stop at Mok Fa waterfall and the roadside coffee stands. Arrive by mid-afternoon to settle into Pai's slow, bohemian rhythm.

Eat — Pai Walking Street night market for cheap, brilliant street food.

Stay — Pai — riverside bungalows or a hillside guesthouse.

DAY 2

Around Pai

Rest day

Leave the bike parked for a morning. Catch dawn at Pai Canyon, soak in the Tha Pai hot springs, wander to the Land Split and the white Wat Phra That Mae Yen for sunset over the valley.

Eat — A long, lazy café breakfast — Pai does these beautifully.

Stay — A second night in Pai.

DAY 3

Pai – Mae Hong Son

📏 110 km · 3 h

The quietest, prettiest leg. Detour to the Tham Lod cave (by bamboo raft and lantern) and the Su Tong Pae bamboo bridge. Mae Hong Son is a calm, Shan-flavoured town ringed by mountains.

Eat — Lakeside stalls by Nong Jong Kham at dusk.

Stay — Mae Hong Son town, near the lake.

The Mae Hong Son Loop

07

DAY 4

Mae Hong Son – Khun Yuam – Mae Sariang

📏 160 km · 4 h

Climb to the Ban Rak Thai tea village near the Myanmar border for breakfast among the hills, then roll south. Khun Yuam's WWII museum makes a thoughtful stop. Mae Sariang is a sleepy riverside town — a lovely place to do nothing.

Eat — Riverside Thai-Shan cooking in Mae Sariang.

Stay — Mae Sariang, by the Yuam river.

DAY 5

Mae Sariang – Mae Chaem

📏 170 km · 4–5 h

A remote, beautiful stretch — fuel up first. The road winds through forest and rice terraces to Mae Chaem, a traditional weaving town few travellers reach. Quiet nights and big stars.

Eat — Simple local kitchens — point and smile.

Stay — Mae Chaem — homestay or small guesthouse.

The Mae Hong Son Loop

07

DAY 6

Mae Chaem – Doi Inthanon – Chiang Mai

📏 150 km · 4 h

Climb to the roof of Thailand (2,565 m) at Doi Inthanon: the twin royal pagodas, cloud forest, and the Pha Dok Siew waterfall trail. Then descend the eastern side back toward Chiang Mai.

Eat — Karen-grown coffee and grilled corn on the mountain.

Stay — Back in Chiang Mai's old city.

DAY 7

Chiang Mai

Slow finish

Reward the ride: a Thai massage, a cooking class, and a wander round the old-city temples and Sunday Walking Street. Toast 1,864 curves survived. Chon kaew!

Eat — One last bowl of khao soi — you've earned it.

Stay — Chiang Mai.

Food on the road

08

Some of Thailand's best meals cost a euro and come from a roadside cart. Look for stalls busy with locals, point if you can't pronounce it, and say 'mai phet' if you'd like it milder.

The North (around the Loop)

Khao soi (curry-noodle soup — the dish of Chiang Mai), sai ua (herby grilled sausage), nam prik num (green-chilli dip with sticky rice), and gaeng hang lay (Burmese-style pork curry).

Central & Bangkok

Pad krapow (holy-basil stir-fry with a fried egg), boat noodles, mango sticky rice, and the green/red curries you know — done properly.

Isaan (North-East)

Som tam (green-papaya salad), larb (zingy minced-meat salad), grilled gai yang chicken and endless sticky rice. Boldly spicy.

The South

Fierier curries rich with turmeric and coconut, fresh seafood, and massaman — fragrant and mild.

Thailand bucket list

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Tick off the experiences as you go.

Survive all 1,864 curves of the Mae Hong Son Loop

Watch dawn mist fill the valley at Pai Canyon

Soak in a natural hot spring after a day's ride

Slurp a bowl of khao soi in Chiang Mai

Climb to Thailand's roof at Doi Inthanon

Share sticky rice with a hill-tribe family

Ride a long-tail boat through Andaman limestone karsts

Cook a curry at a Thai cooking class

Give alms to monks at sunrise

Find an empty beach with no name

Eat at a night market until you can't move

Learn to say 'aroi!' and mean it

Trip budget

09

CATEGORY	PLANNED	ACTUAL
Flights		
Vehicle rental		
Fuel		
Accommodation		
Food & drink		
Activities		
SIM & extras		
Buffer		
TOTAL		

Packing for Thailand

09

RIDING & SAFETY

Helmet (or hire a good one)

Light gloves

Sunglasses

Rain poncho

Closed shoes

TROPICAL KIT

High-SPF sunscreen

Insect repellent (DEET)

Reusable water bottle

Quick-dry clothes

Sarong / scarf

HEALTH

Travel insurance docs

Rehydration salts

Basic first-aid

Hand sanitiser

Any personal meds

DOCUMENTS & TECH

IDP + driving licence

Passport + copies

Offline maps downloaded

Power bank

Universal adapter

PLAN YOUR TRIP

Daily plan

09

Copy or reprint this page for each day of your route.

DAY / DATE

ROUTE — FROM / TO

DISTANCE

DRIVING TIME

OVERNIGHT

STOPS & SIGHTS ALONG THE WAY

WHERE TO EAT

NOTES & MEMORIES



Chok dee

Good luck, and enjoy every curve.

THE SLOW ATLAS · RENNES, FRANCE